



The impact of perceived customer delight on the frontline employee



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ABSTRACT

A plethora of research has investigated the impact of the frontline employee on the customer, with the consensus that employees can have a tremendous impact on the customer. What remains to be discovered is the extent to which this relationship exists in the reverse. Utilizing broaden-and-build and emotional contagion theories, this study suggests that employee perceptions of a specific customer emotion (delight) have an impact on the frontline employee. Specifically, results from a structural equations model reveal that employee perceptions of customer delight lead to employee positive affect, which in turn positively influences commitment and job satisfaction as well as creates stronger external representation behaviors, internal influence behaviors, and service delivery behaviors from the employee. These findings contribute new evidence to the debate of the viability of providing customer delight and extend our knowledge beyond emotional contagion in explaining how positive customer emotions manifest in employees.

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1. Introduction

Currently there is confusion in the marketing literature regarding the viability of customer delight, which is defined as a “profoundly positive emotional state generally resulting from having one’s expectations exceeded” (Oliver, Rust, & Varki, 1997, p. 329). Essentially the debate has been evaluated from both a cost-oriented and customer-oriented perspective. From the former, there is concern over rising customer expectations and declining marginal returns that may exist with a delight initiative (i.e., Rust & Oliver, 2000). From a customer-oriented perspective, where customer satisfaction is considered the paramount goal of the firm, delighting the customer is a logical and necessary goal (i.e., Keiningham & Vavra, 2001).

A third perspective that may contribute to the debate is evaluating customer delight from the viewpoint of frontline employees—those service providers who have direct contact with customers. This is an important perspective for several reasons: (1) employees are a key component of Kotler’s (1994) services marketing triangle model which links the firm with customers; (2) there is evidence that the interactional nature of the service encounter impacts employees as well as customers (i.e., Barnes, Collier, Ponder, & Williams, 2013; Homburg & Stock, 2005); and (3) employee attitudes and behaviors have been

linked to firm success within the service–profit chain framework (Heskett, Jones, Loveman, Sasser, & Schlesinger, 1994).

Unfortunately, this important third perspective has not been considered in previous research on customer delight. As such, the exact nature and power of the effects of delight that may reverberate through the service–profit chain remain unclear. In response to this gap in the literature, this research has two main goals: first, to provide theoretical reasoning for why employee perceptions of customer delight can impact the employee; and second, to formulate a structural model to empirically demonstrate the impact of customer delight on the employee.

2. Literature review

2.1. Why employee satisfaction matters

An important framework that helps to elucidate the importance of frontline employees is the service–profit chain, which establishes causal relationships in a chain formation between internal service quality, the creation of value, and external service quality (Heskett et al., 1994). In other words, the service–profit chain “asserts that satisfied and motivated employees produce satisfied customers and satisfied customers tend to purchase more” (Gelade & Young, 2005, p. 2). Support for this framework has been found across different contexts utilizing multiple methods (i.e., Homburg, Wieseke, & Hoyer, 2009; Kamakura, Mittal, De Rosa, & Mazzon, 2002; Maxham, Netemeyer, & Lichtenstein, 2008). Further, a recent meta-analysis confirms the central links of the service–profit chain, stating that the relationship of employee satisfaction to customer satisfaction is “remarkable” (Brown & Lam, 2008).

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Another aspect of the service–profit chain that is of paramount importance is the link between the framework and firm profitability. For example, research by Homburg et al. (2009) utilizing a large-scale triadic data set provides support for an “extended” service–profit chain which links service quality to important customer (loyalty and willingness to pay) and firm (financial performance) outcomes. Utilizing perceived financial performance, Yee, Yeung, and Cheng (2011) provide evidence for a positive link between the service–profit chain and Return On Assets, Return On Sales, and Return On Investment.

One avenue of research that has not been evaluated within the service–profit chain literature is situations in which employees experience elevated levels of positive affect. This is especially important because employee positive affect has been linked to important outcomes such as job satisfaction, affective commitment and customer-oriented behaviors. If frontline employees experience higher levels of positive affect because of perceived customer delight, they would act as springboards for value creation within the service–profit chain.

2.2. Does customer delight impact the employee?

Because of the interactional nature of a service encounter, employee perceptions of customer delight should impact the employee. Two theories, emotional contagion (Hatfield, Cacioppo, & Rapson, 1994) and broaden-and-build (Fredrickson, 1998, 2001), help to explain this connection.

Emotional contagion refers to situations where “exposure to an individual expressing positive or negative emotions can produce a corresponding change in the emotional state of the observer” (Pugh, 2001, p. 1020). Even in situations characterized by minimal contact, “emotions and attitudinal states can pass between Person A (the initiator) and Person B (the recipient) and leave a permanent trace” (Stock and Hoyer, 2005, p. 540). This phenomenon has appeared in customer settings, where customers who are exposed to the emotional displays of employees experience corresponding changes in their own affective states (Gountas, Ewing, & Gountas, 2007; Hennig-Thurau, Groth, Paul, & Gremler, 2006; Pugh, 2001). For example, customers in a bank setting exhibited higher levels of positive affect and gave higher ratings of service quality when confronted with positive displays of emotion from the employee (Pugh, 2001). Furthermore, and in direct relationship to the present research, the contagion phenomenon that exists from employee to customer also exists from customer to employee in satisfactory encounters (Homburg & Stock, 2004). Thus, the transfer of emotions in *satisfactory* encounters can flow in both directions.

To help understand the flow of contagious positive emotions from the customer to the employee, we utilize a developing theory called the broaden-and-build theory (Fredrickson, 1998, 2001). This theory explains how positive emotions can broaden people’s momentary thought–action repertoires and build their enduring resources, which range from physical and intellectual resources to social and psychological resources (Fredrickson, 2001, 2003). Although discrete emotions (i.e., delight) can be temporary, their effects can be long term (Fredrickson,

2001). Support for the broaden-and-build theory is found in management research that links positive affect to flexible, creative, and efficient employees who are open to information and are better problem solvers (i.e., Isen, 2008; Isen & Baron, 1991).

Taken together, these two theories provide an enticing prediction for why perceived customer delight will impact the employee (see Fig. 1). In the first step, employees who are exposed to perceived customer delight mirror these positive emotions (i.e., increases in employee positive affect vis-à-vis emotional contagion). In the second step, through a broadening and building of the employee’s resources, these positive emotions are changed into resources (i.e., job satisfaction, commitment, and customer orientation) which the employee can access.

3. Model and hypotheses

Based on the stated goals of our research, we develop a model presented in Fig. 2 that examines the direct effects of employee perceptions of customer delight on employee positive affect, and the indirect effects of these perceptions on employee attitudes and behaviors. In the following section, a brief description of each construct and its relevance to the current study is given.

3.1. Employee perceptions of customer delight → employee positive affect

Positive affect reflects the “extent to which a person feels enthusiastic, active, and alert” (Watson, Clark, & Tellegen, 1988, p. 1063), and can be measured as either a trait or a state. The former represents an enduring personality trait that “predisposes people to experience positive emotions and moods as well as to have a positive outlook and orientation” (George & Brief, 1992, p. 318). The latter refers to a more transient affective state, and “captures how one feels at a given point in time” (George & Brief, 1992, p. 318).

There are several reasons why it is important to study the effects of providing customer delight on the state of employee positive affect: (1) states can be determined by situational factors such as service encounters (George & Brief, 1992); (2) positive affect as a state is shown as a significant predictor of customer service behaviors for employees, whereas positive affect as a trait is not (George, 1991); (3) states are expected to have profound effects on thought processes and behaviors in organizational settings (George & Brief, 1992); and (4) states can have duration and breadth to influence outcomes long after they occur (Pelled & Xin, 1999).

As previously stated, the basis for the link between employee perceptions of customer delight and employee positive affect is found in theories related to emotional contagion (Hatfield et al., 1994). Because of the importance of positive employee emotions to service quality evaluations (Pugh, 2001) and firm success (Hennig-Thurau et al., 2006), quantifying the effect of contagion effects in a delightful encounter is an important step for service research. Thus,

H1. Employee perceptions of customer delight have a positive influence on employee positive affect.

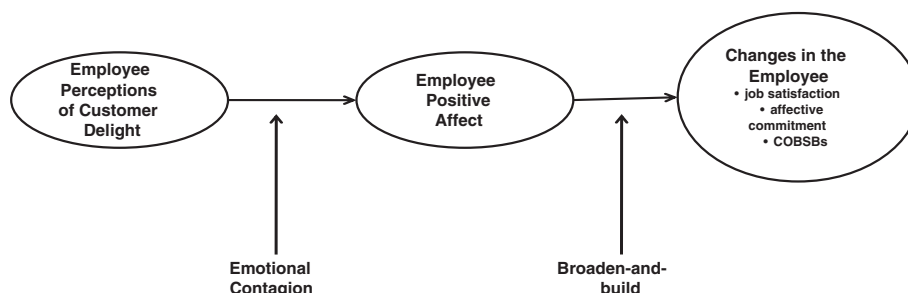


Fig. 1. Combining emotional contagion and broaden-and-build.

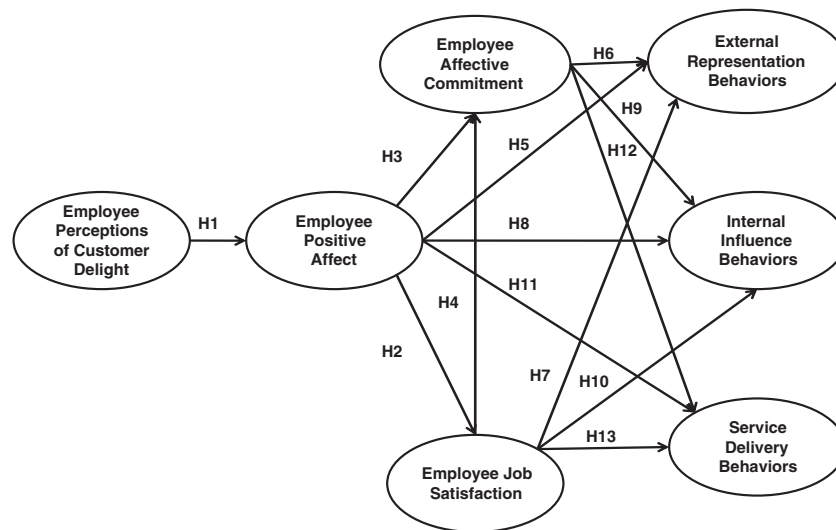


Fig. 2. The impact of perceived customer delight on the frontline employee.

3.2. Employee positive affect → job satisfaction

Similar to previous service research (i.e., Hartline & Ferrell, 1996), Locke's (1976) conceptualization of job satisfaction "as a pleasurable or positive emotional state resulting from a person's appraisal of his or her job or job experiences" is utilized (p. 1300). The link between employee positive affect and job satisfaction has been well established in academic literature. For example, a meta-analysis revealed a high adjusted correlation between job satisfaction and positive affect ($r = 0.34$) (Thoresen, Kaplan, Barsky, Warren, & de Chermont, 2003). Weiss and Cropanzano (1996) also provide support for the power of affect on employee attitudes such as job satisfaction. Relating directly to this research, Niklas and Dormann (2005) found that state affect leads to generalized job satisfaction. Thus,

H2. Employee positive affect has a positive influence on job satisfaction.

3.3. Employee positive affect → affective commitment, and job satisfaction → affective commitment

Organizational commitment is defined as "the strength of an individual's identification with and involvement in a particular organization" (Porter, Steers, Mowday, & Boulian, 1974, p. 604). Although related to job satisfaction, the two constructs differ in that "job satisfaction is viewed as a reflection of immediate reactions to the workplace, (whereas) organizational commitment is believed to develop more slowly as employees learn more about their job and organization" (Parish, Berry, & Lam, 2008, p. 225). Empirical research supports this distinction by showing a causal relationship from job satisfaction to organizational commitment (Parish et al., 2008).

Similar to previous service research (i.e., Dean, 2007; Evanschitzky, Iyer, Plassman, Niessing, & Meffert, 2006; Paulin, Ferguson, & Bergeron, 2006), the component of organizational commitment that is of interest in this context is affective commitment. Theoretical support for why affective commitment alone is an appropriate measure of commitment has been provided in previous service research (i.e., Dean, 2007). Additional support for a focus on affective commitment as the key form of commitment comes from research that shows a strong relationship between affective commitment and employee performance (Malhotra & Mukherjee, 2003; Meyer & Allen, 1991); organizational citizenship behaviors (Organ & Ryan, 1995); and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003).

A strong relationship between affective commitment and employee tenure has also been demonstrated (Malhotra & Mukherjee, 2003; Meyer & Allen, 1991). Furthermore, there is a correlation between positive affect and affective commitment (Herrbach, 2006). Finally, evidence suggests that job satisfaction is an antecedent to customer orientation (Bateman & Organ, 1983) and organizational commitment (i.e., Parish et al., 2008; Porter et al., 1974). Thus,

H3. Employee positive affect has a positive influence on employee affective commitment.

H4. Job satisfaction has a positive influence on employee affective commitment.

3.4. Customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors

Customer orientation is a cornerstone of competitive advantage and occurs when the firm is engaged in the organization-wide generation of, dissemination of, and responsiveness to market intelligence (Brady & Cronin, 2001; Narver & Slater, 1990). Importantly, customer orientation is positively related to profitability (Narver & Slater, 1990). An essential aspect of developing a customer orientation for the service firm is the ability of its workers to engage in boundary-spanning roles that link the firm with the external environment (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003; Bettencourt, Brown, & MacKenize, 2005). These boundary-spanning roles allow the firm to "acquire and assimilate the information necessary to design and execute marketing strategies that result in more favorable customer outcomes" (Brady & Cronin, 2001, p. 241).

Bettencourt and Brown (2003) and Bettencourt et al. (2005) highlight three boundary-spanning employee behaviors that contribute to a customer orientation: (1) external representation, (2) internal influence, and (3) service delivery. These variables appear in our structural model as dependent variables.

3.5. External representation behaviors

External representation behaviors occur when employees are vocal advocates to outsiders of the organization's image, products, and services (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003). External representation, a form of word-of-mouth communication (Shinnar, Young, & Meana, 2004), exists in two forms: referral for use and referral for employment (Parish et al., 2008). Referral for use is likely an outcome of affective

commitment and can be particularly influential within the employee's social network (Parish et al., 2008). Referral for employment is shown to offer several advantages for the firm. For example, employees recruited through referrals have longer tenure (Breugh, 1981); a better understanding of job requirements (Breugh & Mann, 1984); and higher job applicant quality (Breugh, Grising, Taggart, & Helen Chen, 2003; Kirnan, Farley, & Geisinger, 1989).

Employee positive affect leads to spreading goodwill (George & Brief, 1992), which is akin to the external representation behaviors in this research. Organ and Ryan (1995) found that employee positive affect led to increases in citizenship behaviors that benefit the firm. Additionally, previous research shows that job satisfaction and organizational commitment are antecedents to external representation behaviors (Parish et al., 2008). Thus,

H5. Employee positive affect has a positive influence on external representation behaviors.

H6. Employee affective commitment has a positive influence on external representation behaviors.

H7. Job satisfaction has a positive influence on external representation behaviors.

3.6. Internal influence behaviors

Internal influence behaviors occur when employees take individual initiative in communications to the firm and coworkers to improve service delivery by the organization, coworkers, and oneself (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003). For example, an employee could recommend how to perform a specific service task, or make recommendations based on their previous success. Thus, these behaviors lead to the development of knowledge and organizational learning, which has been referred to as the only true source of competitive advantage (Lusch, Vargo, & O'Brien, 2007).

Employees are expected to engage in higher levels of internal influence behaviors for themselves and for others after they have experienced a delightful encounter. Social identity theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1985) offers a social psychology perspective on employee behavior and provides the theoretical underpinnings for why this is likely to occur. Employees identify with the firm and develop a self-concept from the firm's interactions (Ashforth & Mael, 1989). Thus, positive and negative firm interactions are analogous to personal successes and failures. As such, employees who are satisfied and committed are motivated to engage in practices that are most beneficial for the service firm, and by default themselves.

In the context of this research, our model suggests that employees will experience positive affect after they perceive delight from the customer. Because the employee connects these states to the delightful encounter, it is expected that the employee notes which factors contributed to the delightful encounter and then stockpiles these factors for future use. Positive affect also leads to protecting the organization and helping co-workers (George & Brief, 1992), which represents internal influence behaviors. For example, employees in positive moods were more likely to be helpful, regardless of whether the helpful behavior in question was part of their job responsibilities or was above and beyond the call of duty (George, 1991). Thus,

H8. Employee positive affect has a positive influence on internal influence behaviors.

H9. Employee affective commitment has a positive influence on internal influence behaviors.

H10. Job satisfaction has a positive influence on internal influence behaviors.

3.7. Service delivery behaviors

Service delivery behaviors occur when employees serve customers in a conscientious, responsive, attentive, and courteous manner (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003). As an example of the power of these factors, conceptually similar concepts constitute the seminal SERVQUAL model in previous research (Parasuraman, Zeithaml, & Berry, 1988), and have been linked to important outcomes for the firm such as relationship formation and the development of interpersonal bonds (Grewler & Gwinner, 2000).

This research predicts that job satisfaction, affective commitment, and employee positive affect all influence service delivery behaviors. The relationship between job satisfaction and service quality behaviors has been well documented (i.e., Brown & Lam, 2008; Hartline & Ferrell, 1996). Similarly, affective commitment will lead to increases in service delivery behaviors on the basis of social identity theory previously discussed. Finally, this model predicts that increases in employee positive affect will be reflected in increases of service delivery behaviors because of the “feel good–do good” link established in management literature (i.e., George & Brief, 1992). That is, employees in positive moods have a greater ability to “engage others in conversation” (Pelled & Xin, 1999, p. 879), deliver conscientious service, and improve performance (Staw, Sutton, & Pelled, 1994). Thus,

H11. Employee positive affect has a positive influence on service delivery behaviors.

H12. Affective commitment has a positive influence on service delivery behaviors.

H13. Job satisfaction has a positive influence on service delivery behaviors.

4. Method

4.1. Research context and sample

A primary goal herein is to gain a cross-section of service employees with the objective of reducing extraneous influence and increasing the generalizability of findings. To better categorize the industries represented, Bowen's (1990) taxonomy of services was utilized (Gwinner, Grewler, & Bitner, 1998). In this taxonomy, three groupings of service firms exist: Group 1, those services directed at people and characterized by high customer contact with individually customized service solutions (e.g., financial consulting, medical care, and hair care services); Group 2, services directed at an individual's property, in which moderate to low customer contact is the norm and the service can be customized only slightly (e.g., shoe repair, retail banking, and pest control); and Group 3, services typically directed at people that provide standardized service solutions and have moderate customer contact (e.g., airlines, movie theaters, and grocery stores).

In order to obtain this cross-section of service employees, a non-probability snowball sampling technique was orchestrated whereby trained recruiters were required to solicit responses to the survey. The recruiting pool consisted of 80 senior level marketing research students at a large Southeastern university. Training included a thorough discussion of recruiting and screening of potential subjects, as well as an extensive discussion on the importance of developing an authentic sample. Each recruiter received a cover sheet with instructions on the type of service employees they were designated to recruit. Furthermore, detailed descriptions of each group within the taxonomy were provided along with specific examples. Recruiters were encouraged to enlist employees from each of the service categories established by Bowen (1990). Recruiters were eligible for 1/2 percentage point per survey on a graded assignment with a maximum of 5% (n = 10 surveys) bonus.

Recruiters were asked to direct respondents to an online survey which was opened for a period of 14 days. As is the case with previous research utilizing this method, steps were taken to encourage authentic responses (see [Gremler and Gwinner, 2008](#), p. 311). For the purpose of verification, the survey asked respondents to provide their first name and a telephone number. Respondents were further alerted to the fact that they may be contacted in order to assure authenticity. All of the individuals contacted verified their identity and responses. The final sample size was 431, including 183 respondents from Group 1, 138 from Group 2, and 110 from Group 3 of Bowen's taxonomy. Of the total, 54% were female and the average age was 29 years.

As shown in [Fig. 2](#), the proposed model contains seven latent variables, each consisting of multi-item measures. As in previous service employee research, self-rating scales were used for all measures. Further, all of the measures were adapted from scales that had proved reliable in previous studies (see [Table 1](#)). A draft survey was pilot-tested on customer contact employees as well as a convenience sample of academics to establish evidence of face validity. No problems were identified.

4.2. Measures

[Table 1](#) contains a list of items utilized. Employee perceptions of customer delight were measured using three reflective indicators of delight: gleeful, elated, and delighted. Similar measures of customer delight have been accepted in recent literature (i.e., [Wang, 2011](#)). For employee perceptions of customer delight, respondents were asked to give their perception of the extent to which these emotions existed in the customer after a specific employee–customer encounter. Because this research is based on the employee perception of customer emotions, measuring customer delight in this manner is appropriate.

Job satisfaction was measured using a four-item measure adapted from previous service research ([Johlke, Duhan, Howell, & Wilkes, 2000](#)). The scale items reflect overall work satisfaction rather than any specific dimensions of work satisfaction. Measuring satisfaction at this level, as opposed to the specific facets of the job, is recommended when investigating the transference of emotions between customers and employees (i.e., [Brown & Lam, 2008](#)).

Employee positive affect was measured using three items reflective of how employees may feel after a delightful service encounter: enthusiastic, delighted, and excited. These three items were selected because they specifically reference emotions related to the employee's work.

Affective commitment was measured using five items from the Organizational Commitment Questionnaire of [Mowday, Steers, and Porter \(1979\)](#). Similar scale items have been used in previous service research (i.e., [Dean, 2007](#)). The scale “captures identification with the company (pride in belonging), psychological attachment (sense of belonging), concern about the long term success of the company, and feelings of loyalty” ([Dean, 2007](#), p. 166).

The customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors were measured using three components previously employed in service research ([Bettencourt & Brown, 2003](#)). External representation behaviors were measured using a three-item scale designed to capture the extent to which an employee is a vocal advocate to outsiders of the organization's image, goods, and services. Internal influence behaviors were measured with a three-item scale intended to measure the extent to which a person takes individual initiative in communicating to the firm and co-workers about ways to improve service delivery by the organization, co-workers, and oneself. Service delivery behaviors were measured with a three-item scale that reflects the extent to which the employee serves customers in a conscientious, responsive, flexible, and courteous manner.

Table 1
Construct measures and confirmatory factor analysis results.

Construct and scale item	Item mean	Std. dev.	Factor load.	CR	Ave	α
Thinking back to a specific encounter where you delighted a customer, please indicate how often you perceive your customer felt the following emotions:						
Delight ^a				0.81	0.62	0.82
1. Gleeful	3.39	0.88	0.87			
2. Elated	3.41	0.87	0.84			
3. Delighted	3.95	0.72	0.63			
Job satisfaction ^b				0.88	0.71	0.88
1. My job was valuable	6.33	1.03	0.80			
2. My job was interesting	6.00	1.22	0.81			
3. My job was satisfying	6.23	1.15	0.92			
Affective commitment ^c				0.94	0.78	0.94
1. I really cared about the fate of this company	4.26	0.99	0.87			
2. I felt a great deal of loyalty to this company	4.23	0.98	0.93			
3. I was willing to put forth effort to help this company be successful	4.48	0.80	0.86			
4. I felt a sense of belonging to this company	4.31	0.93	0.86			
5. My relationship with my service firm was very important to me	4.32	0.94	0.89			
Employee positive affect ^d				0.97	0.71	0.88
1. When I remember delightful service encounters I feel enthusiastic about my work	4.08	0.71	0.80			
2. When I remember delightful service encounters I feel delighted about my work	4.06	0.77	0.84			
3. When I remember delightful service encounters I feel excited about my work	3.97	0.84	0.90			
External representation behaviors ^d				0.88	0.69	0.86
1. I tell outsiders this is a great place to work	3.95	1.10	0.80			
2. I generate goodwill for my service firm	4.19	0.85	0.80			
3. I say good things about my service firm to others	4.24	0.92	0.89			
Internal influence behaviors ^d				0.90	0.75	0.90
1. I make constructive suggestions for service improvement	4.05	0.95	0.83			
2. I share creative solutions to customer problems with other team members	4.16	0.93	0.89			
3. I encourage co-workers to contribute ideas and suggestions for service improvement	3.92	1.05	0.88			
Service delivery behaviors ^d				0.89	0.65	0.78
1. I follow up in a timely matter to customer requests and problems	4.50	0.67	0.74			
2. Regardless of circumstances, I provide exceptionally courteous and respectful service to customers	4.48	0.73	0.78			
3. I follow through in a conscientious manner on promises to customers	4.48	0.69	0.90			

^a 5 point scale (never–always).

^b 7 point scale (strongly disagree–strongly agree).

^c 5 point scale (strongly disagree–strongly agree).

^d 7 point scale (not at all characteristic of me–extremely characteristic of me).

Table 2
Means, standard deviations (SD) and correlations.^a

	Mean	SD	Delight	JS	EPA	AC	ERB	IIB	SDB
Delight	3.6	0.71	0.62						
JS	6.2	1.14	0.25	0.71					
EPA	4.0	0.70	0.39	0.64	0.71				
AC	4.3	0.84	0.25	0.67	0.59	0.78			
ERB	4.1	0.85	0.32	0.50	0.57	0.75	0.69		
IIB	4.0	0.89	0.26	0.45	0.51	0.54	0.56	0.75	
SDB	4.5	0.61	0.15	0.44	0.44	0.41	0.48	0.45	0.65

JS = job satisfaction, EPA = employee positive affect, AC = employee affective commitment, ERB = external representation behaviors, IIB = internal influence behaviors, and SDB = service delivery behaviors.

^a Average variances extracted are presented in boldface type along the diagonal.

4.3. Measure validation procedures

Anderson and Gerbing's (1988) recommended two-step procedure for testing the hypothesized model was utilized here. First, a seven-factor correlated measurement model was estimated using LISREL 8.72. Results from the measurement model revealed one problem. A high modification index indicated that the error terms for two satisfaction items were related ("My job was valuable" and "I was doing something worthwhile"). To preserve unidimensionality, the item "I was doing something worthwhile," was deleted from the model.

The measurement model achieved an acceptable fit: $\chi^2 = 370.41$, $df = 209$, $p \leq .000$, χ^2/df ratio = 1.77, GFI = 0.93, RMSEA = 0.043 and CFI = 0.99, with all indices at acceptable cut-off ranges (Hu & Bentler, 1995).

In addition to overall model fit, convergent validity, reliability, and discriminant validity of the measures were assessed at the item level. As shown in Table 1, confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) results lend strong support to the convergent validity of all measures, because all estimated loadings of the indicators with the underlying constructs are greater than the recommended 0.50 cutoff and are statistically significant at the 0.05 level (Bagozzi & Yi, 1988). Cronbach's alpha values of all constructs are higher than the 0.70 threshold (Nunnally & Bernstein, 1994), and the minimum reliability (α) of the measures is 0.78.

To examine the internal validity of the measurement model, composite reliability (CR) and average variance extracted (AVE) were calculated (Fornell & Larcker, 1981). All of the CRs are above the recommended 0.70 level (Nunnally & Bernstein, 1994). The AVEs of all constructs, which represent the amount of variance captured by the construct's measures relative to measurement error and the correlations among the latent variables, are higher than the 0.5 cutoff recommended by Fornell and Larcker (1981) for each construct. Thus, there is evidence that the internal validity of the measurement model appears adequate.

Table 3
Results of the structural model.^a

Hypotheses	Coefficient (t-value)	Hypotheses validation
H1: Delight encounter → employee positive affect	0.39 (7.14)	Supported
H2: Employee positive affect → job satisfaction	0.64 (11.66)	Supported
H3: Employee positive affect → affective commitment	0.28 (4.88)	Supported
H4: Job satisfaction → affective commitment	0.49 (8.33)	Supported
H5: Employee positive affect → external representation behaviors	0.26 (4.47)	Supported
H6: Affective commitment → external representation behaviors	0.67 (10.71)	Supported
H7: Job satisfaction → external representation behaviors	−0.11 (−1.76)	Not supported
H8: Employee positive affect → internal influence behaviors	0.31 (4.68)	Supported
H9: Affective commitment → internal influence behaviors	0.34 (5.26)	Supported
H10: Job satisfaction → internal influence behaviors	0.03 (0.40)	Not supported
H11: Employee positive affect → service delivery behaviors	0.26 (3.58)	Supported
H12: Affective commitment → service delivery behaviors	0.16 (2.25)	Supported
H13: Job satisfaction → service delivery behaviors	0.17 (2.15)	Supported

^a $\chi^2 = 419.38$, $df = 217$, χ^2/df ratio = 1.93, $p \leq .000$, RMSEA = 0.046, and CFI = 0.99.

Discriminant validity was further assessed utilizing Fornell and Larcker's (1981) test, whereby AVE estimate for each construct is compared with the squared correlation between any two constructs. This is considered a more rigorous test of the measurement model (Homburg, Hoyer, & Stock, 2007). The AVEs are higher than the squared correlations, confirming the discriminant validity of the constructs (see Table 2).

5. Results

Table 3 provides a summary of results obtained by estimating the hypothesized structural model in Fig. 1. The global goodness-of-fit statistics indicate that the structural model represents the data structure well ($\chi^2 = 419.38$, $df = 217$, χ^2/df ratio = 1.93, $p \leq .000$, RMSEA = 0.047, CFI = 0.99). As such, each hypothesis was tested by examining path significance.

According to the results, employee perceptions of customer delight positively influence employee positive affect (H1), which in turn positively influences job satisfaction (H2) and affective commitment (H3). In accordance with previous research, there is a significant path from job satisfaction to affective commitment (H4). Further, results indicate that employee positive affect positively influences all three of the customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors (H5, H8, and H11). On the other hand, job satisfaction influences only service delivery behaviors (H13), while employee affective commitment influences internal influence behaviors (H6), external representation behaviors (H9), and service delivery behaviors (H12).

Two hypotheses were not supported, both of which considered the influence of job satisfaction on external representation behaviors and internal influence behaviors (H7, H10).

6. Discussion

There has been much discussion within the marketing literature on the feasibility of aiming for customer delight. While previous research showed mixed results, the employee's perspective of a delight initiative had not yet been evaluated. As such, the main goal of this research was to empirically investigate the impact of employee perceived customer delight. Importantly, our discussion and implications rest on the notion that employee perceptions are germane to what the employee feels and ultimately how the employee behaves on the job. Because previous research notes that employees are an excellent source of data for firms (Schneider, Macey, Lee, & Young, 2009), and that their perceptions of customer satisfaction correlate with customers (Schneider & Bowen, 1985), we believe that evaluating employee perceptions offers important insights to both practitioners and researchers (please see Table 4 for a summary of these contributions).

A majority of previous research investigating emotional contagion has evaluated the effects of employee emotions on customers (for an exception see [Homburg & Stock, 2004](#)). The present research provides evidence that this effect also exists in the opposite direction. By showing this link we answer previous calls to research to investigate if and how perceived customer emotions can impact the employee (i.e., [Barsade & Gibson, 2007](#); [Fredrickson, 2001](#)). Furthermore, to the authors' knowledge, no research has empirically evaluated the transfer of emotions from customers to employees in situations characterized as *delightful*. Once again, this research finds support for the transfer of perceived elevated positive emotions between groups. In other words, contagion effects can rise above satisfaction in either direction. This is an important finding as previous research has shown that positive emotions like pleasure (i.e. delight) are very influential on employee attitudes ([Mignonac & Herrbach, 2004](#)).

The transfer of emotions from the customer to the employee is especially important when utilizing broaden-and-build theory as a framework. The key idea espoused by broaden-and-build theory is that positive emotions are essential to human flourishing, and that positive emotions act as “vehicles for individual growth and social connection...” ([Fredrickson, 2001, p. 224](#)). Positive emotions help individuals to flourish, even when dealing in difficult situations (i.e., [Tugade & Fredrickson, 2004](#)). With the dynamic and challenging environment in which frontline employees often find themselves, positive emotions are an important area to study for service researchers. In the current research, we provide support for the main tenets of this theory by showing that employee positive affect leads to the building and broadening of frontline employee attitudes and skills.

[Fig. 2](#) also contributes to the ongoing debate in the management literature on what causes job performance. The results support the “feel good–do good” link previously discussed by [George and Brief \(1992\)](#) among others. That is, what really causes performance is how the employee feels, which may or may not be directly related to job satisfaction. As [Weiss and Cropanzano \(1996\)](#) state: “affective states influence performance and job satisfaction but their performance implications are, by and large, independent of their relationships with satisfaction” (p. 65).

Another important finding of this research is that the antecedent variables that affect different customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors vary. For example, employees with higher levels of job satisfaction are more likely to engage in service delivery behaviors, whereas to engage in internal influence or external representation, employees must first be affectively committed to the firm. Although this relationship was not predicted, there is support in the literature for this unexpected finding. Employees see certain types of customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors as extra-role behaviors, while other types of customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors as role-prescribed behaviors. The former represent actions on which employees are not evaluated, nor are they behaviors that represent a part of their formal job descriptions ([Brief & Motowidlo, 1986](#)). On the other hand, role-prescribed behaviors represent expected employee actions and behaviors in serving the firm's customers ([Brief & Motowidlo, 1986](#)). Such behaviors include “exhibiting common courtesy, demonstrating accurate knowledge of policies and products, addressing customers by name, greeting and saying ‘thank you’ to customers” ([Bettencourt & Brown, 1997, p. 42](#)). These types of behaviors are “derived from implicit norms in the workplace or from explicit obligations as specified in organizational documents” ([Bettencourt & Brown, 1997, p. 42](#)).

The present research also contributes to the customer delight literature. A main finding was that an unintended effect of aiming for customer delight may be employee delight. The effects from this latter delight should then echo through the service–profit chain, which has been shown to be an accurate framework linking employee satisfaction to customer satisfaction and firm profit (i.e., [Brown & Lam, 2008](#); [Homburg et al., 2009](#)). As such, one of the biggest outcomes of pursuing customer delight has not yet been considered in the debate on the value of it.

Finally, the value of human resource management for a service firm cannot be overstated. In service encounters where employee–customer interactions are important quality indicators, it is imperative to hire and train effectively. Identifying those employees who have a greater ability to experience contagion effects from the customer, as well as placing those employees in situations where they can delight the customer represent important challenges to the service firm. This should include

Table 4
Summary of contributions.

Hypothesis	Expected relationship/ representative article(s)	Finding	Contribution(s)
H1: Delight encounter → employee positive affect	Unknown, (n/a)	(+)	Provides evidence for the transference of emotions from the customer to the FLE for elevated emotional levels. This is especially important when considering the impact of the FLE on value creation within the service–profit chain framework. Moreover, although what actually delights customers may differ across contexts, the impact of perceived delight on the employee is more consistent.
H2: Employee positive affect → job satisfaction	(+), Thoresen et al. (2003)	(+)	Provides support for the impact of positive affect on job satisfaction and affective commitment. We augment previous research by testing these relationships across industry type, as well as adding a more complex understanding of the impact of positive affect beyond emotional contagion.
H3: Employee positive affect → affective commitment	(+), Parish et al. (2008)	(+)	
H4: Job satisfaction → affective commitment	(+), Parish et al. (2008)	(+)	Provides support for the impact of job satisfaction on affective commitment. We augment previous research by testing this relationship across industry type.
H5, H8, H11: EPA → customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors	(+), Organ and Ryan (1995) , George (1991)	(+)	Provides support for the impact of positive affect on prosocial behaviors. This research is the first to empirically test the relationship of EPA to a specific form of boundary spanning behaviors (customer-oriented). Furthermore, we tested these relationships across industry type (previous studies have utilized retail bank FLEs exclusively: Bettencourt & Brown, 2003 ; Bettencourt et al., 2005). Finally, we add a more complex theoretical understanding of why positive affect is likely to impact the dependent variables (broaden-and-build theory of positive emotions).
H6, H9, H12: Affective commitment → customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors	(+), Bettencourt et al. (2005)	Mixed	Suggests the relationship between affective commitment/job satisfaction and COBSBs is more complex than previously modeled. That is, some COBSBs are seen as extra-role behaviors while others are seen as in-role behaviors. For example, for employees to engage in service delivery behaviors they must be satisfied with their job. But, to engage in either internal influence or external influence behaviors, they must be affectively committed to their job.
H7, H10, H13: Job satisfaction → customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors	(+), Bettencourt et al. (2005)	Mixed	

some analysis of the interviewee's disposition regarding the importance of the customer, as well as their understanding of what customer delight represents. Moreover, reward structures or contests may stimulate a focus on customer delight. Furthermore, it is imperative that firms manage not only customer emotions but also employee emotions. The goal of the firm should be to expose frontline employees to delighted customers to harness the power of contagion emotions. This could be done by encouraging delighted customers to share their experiences with the frontline employee vis-à-vis real time surveys or other similar methods in exchange for future discounts.

6.1. Limitations and future research

Although the current research contributes to the understanding of how customer emotions affect employee behaviors and attitudes, there are limitations that should be acknowledged. The most significant potential limitations deal with the operationalization and measurement of the exogenous construct of employee perceptions of customer delight: first, this construct represents a very narrow representation of positive customer emotions. In future research, a broader spectrum of emotions should be included in evaluating the model in Fig. 2. Second, the factor loading of 0.63 for the "delight" item falls below the ideal 0.70 threshold. Third, our conceptualization excluded non-delighted customers from analysis. This may represent a bias as delighted customers represent a smaller proportion of the customer base in comparison with satisfied customers. Fourth, we utilized three measures of customer delight to represent the sole exogenous construct in our model, and any excluded exogenous constructs that are correlated with customer delight could bias all of the parameter estimates. Thus, model underspecification is a possibility. Fifth, this study assessed employee perceptions of customer delight without verifying that delight had occurred from the customer's point-of-view. Because our focus was *only* on employee perceptions of customer delight, the actual occurrence of delight from the customer's viewpoint was not germane to this research. However, future studies could evaluate the correlation between employee and customer perceptions of delight with dyadic data. Aside from potential issues with the exogenous variable, data were collected utilizing multiple recruiters as well as with a snowballing procedure, both of which have weaknesses. For example, a selection bias may exist in the data set. Finally, with regard to causality, data were collected in a cross-sectional manner; a stronger case for causality would be made with longitudinal or experimental data.

Aside from these limitations, there are many avenues of future research that can develop from the findings presented. For example, there are several topics relating to emotional contagion that warrant further research, including developing an emotional contagion scale for the service environment; illustrating how long the effects of contagion last; whether contagion differs across employee populations. Furthermore, this research considered only positive emotions; it would be interesting to evaluate how negative emotions relate to the relationships shown in our model.

Another interesting area of future research would be to evaluate different outcome variables in comparison with customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors. For example, adaptability is an important component in service quality evaluations (Gwinner, Bitner, Brown, & Kumar, 2005), and a positive relationship likely exists between employees in an elevated mood state and ability and desire to engage in adapting behaviors for the benefit of the firm/customer. Future research could investigate the impact of emotional contagion on non-frontline employees, such as repairmen or auto workers. Is the flow of positive emotions from customer to employee as strong if there is no direct contact between the two? Finally, future research should incorporate a quantitative measure of profit in relation to the impact of perceived customer delight. As relevant research has shown a link between customer delight and variables such as willingness to pay (i.e.,

Barnes, Beauchamp, & Webster, 2010), it is likely that a positive relationship exists between customer delight and firm profit.

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